scientists at Farm Hall confirmed what documents captured by Alsos had already suggested: the Nazi bomb program, unlike the Manhattan Project, was a disorganized mess, with vital information compartmentalized and no clear vision of how to proceed. Yet, in those same few days, the Farm Hall transcripts make it clear that Heisenberg and his student, Carl von Weizsäcker, purposefully constructed a revisionist narrative of their wartime activities. According to them, while the Americans had built a weapon of death and destruction on unprecedented scales, they, the Germans, had deliberately pursued only a nuclear reactor, being unwilling to build a massive new weapon for Hitler's Reich—thereby placing the responsibility for their failure on their supposed moral clarity, rather than their sheer incompetence.

While Heisenberg had been working to such honorable ends during the war, his mentor had been nearly killed. Bohr had returned to Copenhagen after his visit to America in 1939, arriving home several months before the outbreak of war that September. Germany invaded Denmark before sunrise on the morning of April 9 the following year; two hours later, the Danish government surrendered. Hitler was determined to make Denmark a "model protectorate," demonstrating his peaceful ways to the rest of the world. He managed to curb his bloodlust and refrained from imposing anti-Semitic laws on the Danes for over three years. Finally, in October 1943, the SS arrived in the streets of Copenhagen. They planned to round up the city's Jews during Rosh Hashanah, the Jewish New Year and one of the holiest days on the Jewish calendar. But when they went from door to door, they found that nearly all the Jews in the city had simply vanished. A German diplomat, Georg Duckwitz, had warned the leaders of Denmark's Jewish community days earlier, and most of the country's Jews had gone into hiding by the time the SS arrived. One of them was Niels Bohr, who had been ferried to safety in a fishing boat along with his family across the Øresund strait and into neutral Sweden three days before the Nazis arrived to arrest him at his institute. In Stockholm, Bohr met with King Christian X and pled his case, asking the king to offer Danish Jews asylum in Sweden.